

FROM THE EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

If one were to count only the tonnage of bombs and the range of missiles, a conclave in times of war might seem an exercise in futility. Yet anyone alive to the power of ideas knows that's where everything begins. Both war and peace. Conflicts originate in thoughts and words which, if guided by care, can be shaped into dialogue. When we chose 'Breakthroughs & Breakdowns' as the theme for the India Today Conclave 2026, we were responding to broad global trends. The first part was evident: Artificial Intelligence (AI) has just put humanity into a new orbit. The second part, Breakdowns, was meant to capture the unsettled drift of geopolitics. Little did we know that, on the eve of the conclave, Donald Trump would bring that aspect so palpably to life. As events unfolded, the shadow of war loomed large. All the words spoken by our guests, recorded in this issue, were uttered while missiles and drones were flying in the Middle East, and the world was staring at an energy crisis. In that charged atmosphere, the conclave became a vast forum where the galaxy of eminent guests articulated a spectrum of views and ideas on war and diplomacy, trade, business, and the evolving frontiers of technology.

Sergio Gor, the US ambassador to India, set a tone that resonated among the principal actors in the war: friendship with India. Significantly, he placed this not within the narrow confines of the present conflict but within a longer arc of technological collaboration that the two nations are poised to shape together. "In the US-India relationship, we are seeing not breakdowns, but breakthroughs," Gor said, talking of a coming 'Pax Silica', a strategic marshalling of the entire silicon ecosystem with India among America's first trusted partners. This vision, he suggested, would underpin both strategic coordination and the recently concluded trade deal. His counterparts from Israel and Iran, in their sessions, strikingly converged on the point of amity with India. Israel's Reuven Azar spoke of a "special strategic partnership" and acknowledged India's multilateral stance as "legitimate and unique". Iran's Mohammad Fathali, too, cited ongoing exemptions to India at the Strait of Hormuz as signalling "longstanding friendship and shared interests". In a moment when aligning with all sides may appear fraught, this convergence underscores India's potential to serve as the bridge in a divided world.



▲ Apr. 3, 2023

A lot of public attention came to be focused on the theatrical moments provided by Trump loyalist Laura Loomer, who conveyed a message from the US president: "I love India. I love Modi, and I love the Indian people." Fittingly, she tempered her India-baiting, issuing a veto only on H-1B visas; the drama heightened when she was confronted on her Islamophobia. Less attention was paid to the soft-spoken Dr Abdul Majid Hakeem Ilahi, representative of Iran's Supreme Leader, who received an ovation as he referenced Ayatollah Khamenei's connection to India and his deep admiration for our secularism and Mahatma Gandhi. Meanwhile, European representatives reflected a continent deep in strategic introspection, grappling with the uncertainties of a rapidly shifting global order.

The turbulence of geopolitics lent urgency to the arguments of captains of industry. Citing the prevailing global energy insecurity, Anil Agarwal, chairman, Vedanta Group, called for resource nationalism, saying India was held back by a poverty of intent, not of resources. Energy, ports, logistics and transportation, all in the eye of the Gulf storm, are also the core business of the transnational enterprise Karan Adani represents. The managing director of Adani Ports & SEZ Ltd, therefore, voiced a truism when he said: "Having your own infrastructure becomes extremely critical for a country to make sure your supply chain is stable."

The topic of AI saw rich exchanges, a mix of excitement and dread. As I said in my welcome speech, "AI is like fire. It can cook your food, or it can burn down your house." Harvard Business School professor Christina M. Wallace said individuals with more eclectic interests can adapt better to a world that is "changing every week". Salim Ismail, founder of OpenExO and Singularity University, took adaptivity to the organisational level, saying disruptive technology needs to be first harnessed at the edge to evade "immune responses", citing Apple as an example. From warfare to surgery, fascinating presentations gave us glimpses of how technology is transforming entire domains. Meredith Whittaker, president, Signal Foundation, a high-profile conscientious objector to technology's dark side, raised a cautionary note on Agentic AI's threat to cyber security. Author Pico Iyer brought conversations back to a human scale by talking on "the art of stillness in a restless world".

Equally compelling strands emerged in other sessions, from the upcoming electoral battle in the South to Dubai's durability as a real estate market, to gold in an uncertain currency environment. The world of cinema contributed depth as well as glamour. Anil Kapoor was charming and humble about the longevity of his career. Akshay Kumar got serious about the art of comedy, calling it the "hardest genre" of acting. In sport, emerging cricketing talents Sanju Samson and Abhishek Sharma recalled the hard yards they each put in to reach World Cup glory.

The arc of missiles can never bend towards harmony. To restore balance, an exchange of ideas in the time of disruption is not incidental but essential. This issue is dedicated to building a reserve of those rare and necessary munitions of peace: ideas and dialogue.

(Aroon Purie)